

Credit Card 2.0

Citibank will start testing Card 2.0 a new credit and debit card device that claims to securely link multiple accounts

391,832

That is the number of secret Iraq War documents that WikiLeaks has released, which is touted as the biggest military leak in history

Gaming comes to Tata Sky and Hungama

Tata Sky and Hungama Digital Media Entertainment have teamed up again to bring gaming into your living room, via the television. Calling it a global first, the duo offer “high-end Java-based gaming” that’s developed by Hungama Game Studio, via Tata Sky’s Active platform. The two first teamed up on Active Mall. Vikram Mehra, CMO of Tata Sky, said it was all an effort to deliver casual gaming to the 130 million TV homes in India, of which only 10 million own PCs, and 1 million own gaming consoles (and, Tata Sky just hit a subscriber base of 6 million).

The DTH service announced the value-add can be tried free by subscribers for a 15 day trial period before they choose to invest in the ₹40 for a months package. The service was soft-launched almost a fortnight before its official launch, and Tata Sky claimed they snagged



35,000 Active Games subscribers, without any advertising.

As for the platform itself, Tata Sky and Hungama officially launched it with what they call a celebrity/sports game - Yuvraj Singh Cricket Championship, obviously connecting it with one of India’s favourite past times. Neeraj Roy, CEO of Hungama DME, said that they intend to cater to the entire family, and deliver around 50 games over the course of the year, in various genres. To further differentiate it from embedded games on modern televisions, Hungama Game Studios aims to provide many new games every month **d**

OpenOffice forked as LibreOffice

In order to ramp up the evolution of OpenOffice.org, community members have decided to fork the project and develop it under an independent foundation. For this purpose they have set up The Document Foundation which will be driving the further development of OpenOffice.org under its new name LibreOffice.

OpenOffice.org is possibly the most popular open source office suite for Windows and Linux, and has a port available for Mac OSX as well. It was mainly developed by Sun, and used as a base for their own commercial version of the suite called StarOffice. With the recent acquisition of Sun by Oracle, OpenOffice.org is now in development

under Oracle. The Document Foundation also needs Oracle’s approval before using the OpenOffice.org brand, hence the name “LibreOffice,” and in case they do get Oracle’s approval, it will simplify matter quite a bit as the office suite could then continue to go by its original familiar name under the new foundation.

What The Document Foundation is aiming to do is similar to what has happened with Firefox. Mozilla Firefox’s past lies in the Netscape browser which was open sourced and developed by the independent Mozilla Foundation into what it is today. Hopefully, LibreOffice will have a similar effect on Microsoft Office as Firefox had on Internet Explorer.

Certainly a vendor-independent open source office suite which can challenge the foothold of Microsoft Office is beneficial to the open source community. Hopefully, Oracle will be kind enough to donate the OpenOffice.org brand **d**



MIT: Linux will be multi-core ready

Three MIT professors and their students decided to undertake research in multi-core scalability, i.e., if you keep increasing the number of cores, can you make sure that performance keeps up?

They found that they could, but only by modifying the way the operating system worked, by addressing “clogged refer-

ence counters” that occurred as they kept scaling up the cores. Since multi-core systems end up tasking multiple cores with calculations that require the same data set, the data remains stranded with one or the other cores during the course of the calculation. When a core starts work on the data, it sets a central (available to other cores) counter up, and when it finishes its task on the data, it sets

the counter down. The counter keeps realtime record of which cores are using the data, and when the counter resets itself to zero, the OS then deletes the data, and frees up the processor memory for other tasks.

As one keeps increasing the number of cores however, what happens is that the data gets split into ever smaller portions. This results in the cores “spending so much time ratch-

eting the counter up and down that they weren’t getting nearly enough work done.”

All they had to was to rewrite the Linux code slightly, instructing each core to keep a local count that was only periodically synchronized with the central reference counter, resulting in much improved overall performance. Well, to modify the system, it had to be open-source (at least legally) **d**